



IGNATIUS
**BOOK
BATTLE**

Ignatius Book Battle Competition Manual

2026-27 Competition Year

IN THE CASE OF GOOD BOOKS, THE POINT IS
NOT TO SEE HOW MANY OF THEM YOU CAN
GET THROUGH, BUT RATHER HOW MANY CAN
GET THROUGH TO YOU.

Mortimer Jerome Adler

LET US LEARN UPON THOSE THINGS ON EARTH
WHICH CAN LEAD US TO HEAVEN.

Saint Jerome

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Chapter One

INTRODUCTION

WHO WE ARE

The Ignatius Book Battle turns great reading into a team sport. Students dive into excellent books, the kind that are true, good, and beautiful, then go head-to-head in a lively competition built on knowledge, quick thinking, and teamwork.

The contest is what makes it fun. The real win is everything students gain along the way: stronger reading comprehension, sharper critical thinking, real teamwork, and growth in virtue, character, and moral wisdom. Whether a team takes home the trophy or not, every student leaves having wrestled with great books, grown in wholesome values, and become a sharper thinker along the way.

ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE

Ignatius Book Battle (IBB) is a program of Ignatius Book Fairs. The IBB Coordinator, a dedicated member of the Ignatius Book Fairs team, oversees the program's administration and ongoing development, which includes:

- Publishing the annual official booklist
- Creating Diocesan-level competition questions
- Providing competition resources, materials, and certificates
- Supporting Diocesan Coordinators
- Reviewing and revising program materials and procedures each year
- Organizing a national competition, when applicable

ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

DIOCESAN COORDINATOR RESPONSIBILITIES

The Diocesan Coordinator may be a school, district, or organization employee, librarian, teacher, or parent who has completed the required background screening or safe environment process. Responsibilities include:

- Promote the Ignatius Book Battle within the diocese
- Coordinate communication with participating schools and coaches, clearly communicating rules and event details.
- Select and secure competition sites and dates.
- Organize volunteers and officials:
- Clearly communicate role responsibilities.
- Preparing volunteer binders with competition questions (printed on distinct colored paper), competition rules, scoring sheets, and warning forms
- Preparing competition materials and schedule
- Facilitate event logistics, including speakers, opening and closing remarks, and overall event flow
- Conduct post-event evaluation and provide feedback to IBB.

COACH RESPONSIBILITIES

The coach, an enthusiastic parent volunteer, teacher, or school librarian who loves reading, leads the team, supports students' reading growth, and prepares them for competition..

- Promote good sportsmanship and teamwork.
- Provide books and reading guidance for students.
- Schedule and facilitate practices.
- Communicate expectations and competition details to families.
- Review competition rules with students.
- Prepare practice questions.
- Provide official competition roster of team to Diocesan Coordinator at least 3 weeks prior to competition day.

PARTICIPANT RESPONSIBILITIES

Students in grades 4–5 or 6–8 participate as team members, preparing through reading, practice, and teamwork.

- Demonstrate good sportsmanship and respectful conduct.
- Read assigned books and prepare for competition.
- Attend practices and competitions.
- Work collaboratively with teammates.

COMPETITION OFFICIALS

Each competition room should be staffed with the following volunteers:

REQUIRED (MINIMUM STAFFING PER ROOM):

- 1 Moderator
- 1 Scorekeeper
- 1 Timekeeper
- 1 Judge

RECOMMENDED:

- An additional Judge
- Room Assistants

VOLUNTEER GUIDELINES

- Unless otherwise directed by the host organization, each participating school is expected to provide at least one volunteer to assist with the competition.
- Volunteer assignments should be scheduled so they don't conflict with their own school's competition rounds.
- Volunteers should review the rules and procedures before the competition.

MODERATOR

The Moderator is responsible for directing the flow and pacing of each competition round.

RESPONSIBILITIES

- Read all questions exactly as written.
- Clearly state the player's name before reading the question.
- Repeat the player's name following the question to indicate the official start of timing.
- Repeat questions once upon request while official timing continues.
- Wait for confirmation from the judges before proceeding to the next question.
- Maintain consistent pacing and professionalism throughout the round.
- Announce challenge rulings as directed by the judges.
- Ensure all participants can clearly hear questions and instructions.

SCOREKEEPERS

Scorekeepers ensure accurate, consistent scoring throughout the competition.

RESPONSIBILITIES

- Record points earned for each question.
- Track rebound opportunities and scoring.
- Maintain an accurate running total for each team.
- Verify final scores at the conclusion of each round.
- Ensure a coach from each team reviews and signs the official score sheet before submission.
- Submit completed score sheets to the Diocesan Coordinator promptly following each round.
- Accuracy and consistency are essential.
- Scorekeepers should immediately notify judges of any scoring discrepancies.

TIMEKEEPERS

Timekeepers ensure accurate, consistent timing throughout each competition round.

RESPONSIBILITIES

- Monitor the 20-second response period for primary questions.
- Monitor the 10-second response period for rebound questions.
- Clearly signal when time has expired, by simply stating "Time".
- Use consistent timing procedures throughout all rounds.

JUDGES

Judges ensure fair, consistent, and impartial competition throughout each round.

RESPONSIBILITIES

- Monitor the conduct and behavior of competing teams.
- Determine whether answers are correct or incorrect.
- Rule on challenges involving procedures, timing, questions, answers, and competition conduct.
- Ensure competition procedures are applied consistently throughout all rounds.
- Issue official warnings for unsportsmanlike conduct or inappropriate conferring.
- Maintain a professional, impartial, and orderly competition environment.

ROOM ASSISTANTS

Scorekeepers ensure accurate, consistent scoring throughout the competition.

RESPONSIBILITIES

- Distribute programs and materials.
- Assist with seating for teams and spectators.
- Help supervise entryways and room traffic.
- Escort teams to competition rooms when multiple rooms are being used.
- Help maintain a quiet and orderly competition environment.

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ELIGIBILITY & PARTICIPATION

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- Teams may represent Catholic schools, homeschool groups, or Diocesan youth programs, and other schools or groups at the discretion of the Diocesan Coordinator.
- Students must compete within the designated grade divisions.
- Each team must have an approved coach.
- Each school may send one team per division unless otherwise approved.
- Official rosters may include up to 12 students and up to 2 alternates. The alternates may participate if original team members are unable to attend and the coach has notified the Diocesan Coordinator.

Chapter Four

COMPETITION PROCEDURES

OVERVIEW

Competition schedules should be designed so that each team competes against every other team at least once and has an equitable opportunity to receive the first question during rounds. The number of rounds required will depend on the total number of teams participating.

QUESTIONS

- Each round consists of twelve questions.
- Questions will be read once and may be repeated once upon request.
- Teams may confer only during the official response period.
- Audience prompting will result in question disqualification.
- Diocesan Coordinator

DISTRIBUTION OF QUESTIONS

- IBB will distribute questions to the Diocesan Coordinator a few days prior to the competition date.
- With the help of the IBB Coordinator, the Diocesan Coordinator will determine the number of rounds needed based upon the number of teams participating. An additional (2) extra rounds for tiebreakers and other situations will be provided.
- Questions may not be shared with coaches or used for practice prior to the competition.

SCORING & CHALLENGES

- Two points are awarded for a correct title, as it appears on the official booklist.
- One bonus point is awarded for the correct author.
- Rebound opportunities are worth title points only.
- Each team is allowed one challenge per round.
- Challenges must be initiated immediately following the disputed action.
- Teams have up to three minutes to provide verification.
- The Diocesan Coordinator may determine whether round scores will be announced publicly at the conclusion of each round or released at another designated time.

Chapter Five

OFFICIAL COMPETITION RULES

PHOTOGRAPHY & VIDEO RECORDING

- Flash photography and video recording are prohibited.
- Coaches will be responsible for informing competition officials if a player does not have a photo release.

BOOKS & ELECTRONIC DEVICES

- Each team must bring a complete printed set of the current official IBB books for use during challenges. Books must remain concealed in a bag, box, or other covered container when not in use for a challenge.
- Electronic versions of books are not permitted.
- Competing students may not use electronic devices during competition rounds. Prohibited devices include, but are not limited to, cell phones, smart watches, tablets, laptops, e-readers, and similar electronic devices.
- Except during an official challenge, teams may not access books from the current IBB booklist during competition rounds.
 - Students with documented accommodations may use approved electronic devices as specified in their IEP, 504 Plan, or other applicable accommodation plan.

TEAM COMPOSITION & PARTICIPATION

- Only six students may actively compete during a given round.
- Teams must provide official rosters to the Diocesan Coordinator at least 3 weeks prior to competition day.

RESPECTFUL ENVIRONMENT

- Competition officials may remove disruptive spectators.
- To help maintain a respectful and focused competition environment, spectators are encouraged to save applause and cheering until the conclusion of each round.

TEAM ATTIRE AND DRESS CODE

- Treat all participants, officials, and spectators with respect.
- Demonstrate Christian charity and sportsmanship.
- Accept official decisions graciously.
- Encourage positive and respectful audience behavior.
- Represent schools and dioceses with integrity.
- All participants are expected to follow diocesan and school dress code standards.
- Teams may wear school uniforms, school spirit wear, or Ignatius Book Battle team shirts during competitions. However, team apparel may not display:
 - titles of books on the current IBB booklist,
 - author names from the current IBB booklist,
 - or quotations from books on the current IBB booklist.

FINAL AUTHORITY

- Judges' decisions are final unless otherwise specified.

Chapter Six

TIMELINE & EVENT PLANNING

May to November	Registration and diocesan planning
Summer to Spring	Student reading and team preparation
Winter to Spring	Practice competitions and team selection
Spring	Diocesan competitions
Late Spring	Announcement of next year's booklists

EVENT PLANNING RECOMMENDATIONS

- Provide clear parking and arrival instructions.
- Provide clear signage throughout the facility.
- For larger competitions, consider conducting simultaneous rounds to reduce the overall event duration, and/or create a more efficient experience for participants, volunteers, and spectators.
- Use color-coded materials for volunteers and officials.
- Provide designated waiting areas for teams.
- Communicate lunch plans in advance. Some options include bring your own, food/coffee trucks, local group prepares and sells lunch
- Distribute schedules and room assignments in advance.
- Plan for opening prayer and a brief time to review expectations for participants and spectators

EVENT ATMOSPHERE & HOSPITALITY

Creating a welcoming and joyful environment can help make the competition a memorable experience for students and families. Consider:

- Playing quiet background music as participants arrive and between rounds
- Decorating with balloons, banners, posters, or book-themed decorations
- Providing hospitality for volunteers, officials, and guests.
- Designating an area for team and group photographs.

SUGGESTED MATERIALS & SITE CONSIDERATIONS

A well-organized competition space helps everything run smoothly and makes the day feel special for students and families alike. The materials and considerations below will help hosts prepare a welcoming, well-equipped venue, from clear signage and reliable timing tools to small touches like a photo backdrop that add to the excitement of the day.

- Team name cards/posters and participant name cards (using bold, legible print that can be easily read at a distance). Teams may be invited to create and bring their own team name card/poster displaying their school name and/or team name, helping to foster team identity and school spirit.
- Printed schedules and programs, using the provided IBB Program Template
- Printed score sheets and timing devices (a stopwatch, timer, or smartphone timer is sufficient)
- Participation certificates, using provided IBB template
- Medals or trophies
- Adequate seating for teams and spectators
- Easels for each competition room for displaying team name poster/card
- Clearly marked competition rooms
- Sound system and microphones, if needed
- Create a themed photo backdrop
- Hospitality area

AWARDS & RECOGNITION

- The Diocesan Coordinator is responsible for organizing awards and recognition for participating teams and students. Suggested awards include:
 - A certificate of participation for all competitors
 - A traveling trophy for the 4th–5th grade division champions and another for the middle school division champions.
 - Medals for members of the winning teams.

PROMOTION & COMMUNICATION

- Participating schools, groups, and other organizations are encouraged to promote the Ignatius Book Battle within their local communities. Promotion efforts may include:
- Sharing event information, updates, and photographs through community communication channels.
- Creating and distributing event materials such as programs, posters, banners, flyers, and digital graphics.
- Recognizing participating students, coaches, volunteers, and schools through newsletters, websites, social media, and local announcements.
- Submitting articles, event recaps, and student success stories to school, parish, diocesan, and community publications.
- Contacting local newspapers, media outlets, school communications offices, and community publications before and after the competition. Organizers are encouraged to provide media contacts with event details, photographs, participant information, and post-event results to help generate coverage and recognize student achievement.

A NOTE FROM OUR MARKETING TEAM

Collect photographs, articles, testimonials, and other event highlights to share with Ignatius Book Battle for promotional and program-development purposes. We encourage schools and organizations to share updates throughout the year—from team formation and reading milestones to practices and competition day—so we can celebrate and showcase the entire Book Battle journey alongside you.

Contact marketing@ignatiusbookclub.com for questions regarding marketing and promotion of your event.

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- Appendix H: Scoresheet Template

APPENDIX A

TIPS FOR COACHES

- Set a regular practice schedule and communicate it clearly to students and parents.
- Ensure students become familiar with book titles and authors early in the preparation process.
- Read and review books alongside students whenever possible.
- Encourage students to read as many books as possible.
- Using the book summary sheet on the IBB webpage, work with students to develop practice questions and conduct mock battles to prepare teams for competition.
- Review competition rules and procedures with students and volunteers.
- Promote good sportsmanship and teamwork throughout the season.
- Consider strategic seating arrangements for competition rounds to encourage balanced team participation. Coaches may find it helpful to arrange students so that all team members can easily contribute to discussions and hear one another clearly.

GOOD SPORTSMANSHIP RECOMMENDATIONS

- Coaches and coordinators are encouraged to emphasize that participation in the Ignatius Book Battle and the opportunity to read and engage with great books are accomplishments in themselves. Students should be reminded to approach each competition round with humility, grace, and respect for their fellow participants.
- Creating a positive and encouraging atmosphere helps all students feel welcomed and valued. Teams are encouraged to greet one another and make introductions before each round, as well as congratulate opposing teams afterward. Throughout the competition, remind students that their words, actions, and attitudes reflect not only on themselves, but also on their school, parish, and diocese.

APPENDIX B

GUIDELINES FOR WRITING QUESTIONS

IBB uses the following criteria to develop our questions. Official competition questions are not shared with coaches or participants in advance of the book battle. However, coaches are encouraged to work with team members to develop practice questions and conduct mock battles leading up to the competition. The below criteria will help guide your team in preparing for the competition.

- Read each book completely before writing questions.
- Avoid using major character names or key setting names in questions whenever possible.
- Avoid:
 - vague questions that could apply to multiple books
 - Pronouns as much as possible
 - Major words that appear in a book's title
 - Questions that can be answered by more than one title. For example, "In which book does a character adopt an orphaned creature from the wild?" This can apply to PAX and The Wolf and the Shield
 - Questions that are too vague. For example, "In which book are there siblings whose parents died at a young age?" This can apply to Peter Nimble and His Fantastic Eyes and A Place to Hang the Moon.
- Questions should follow the format: "In which book..."
- Answer Format: Title, Author, Page number (for reference if there is a challenge)
- Use proper grammar, spelling, and punctuation and make note of the page number the question is from.
- Questions should focus only on content written by the author.

SAMPLE QUESTIONS

In which book is there a boy who likes to eat lemons and thinks they're better than oranges any day of the week?	Owls in the Family by Farley Mowat	4
In which book do the ingredients of a game consist of scarlet ribbon and sticks?	The Green Ember by S.D. Smith	11
In which book is a character required to read two pages from the Bible each day to practice reading?	Blue Willow by Doris Gates	34
In which book is a character described as being a giant of a man with huge arms who could crack the ribs of a man as easily as a child could snap a twig?	The Bronze Bow by Elizabeth George Speare	20
In which book does a widowed mother say, "Families should stick together through the lean times as well as the fat"?	The Family Under the Bridge by Natalie Savage Carlson	16
In which book does a character draw spots all over his face with red ink?	Cheaper by the Dozen by Frank B. Gilbreth Jr. and Ernestine Gilbreth Carey	88

APPENDIX C

IGNATIUS BOOK BATTLE BOOK SELECTION CRITERIA

- Books should promote the true, the good, and the beautiful.
- A variety of reading levels, genres, and themes should be represented.
- Books should be age-appropriate and aligned with Catholic values.
- Titles must be currently available or in print.
- Only one book from a series may appear on a yearly list.

APPENDIX D

SAMPLE COMPETITION DAY SCHEDULE

- 8:00 AM – Registration & Check-In
- 8:30 AM – Opening Prayer & Welcome
- 9:00 AM – Round 1 Begins
- 11:30 AM – Lunch Break
- 12:15 PM – Afternoon Rounds
- 2:30 PM – Championship Round
- 3:15 PM – Awards Ceremony & Closing Prayer

APPENDIX E

SUGGESTED PHYSICAL ARRANGEMENT FOR COMPETITIONS

Top-down floor plan layout with teams facing the audience and the moderator facing the teams.

Teams facing the audience.
Moderator facing the teams.



- 1 Moderator (1)
- 2 Team A
- 3 Team B
- 4 Timekeepers (2)
- 5 Judges (3)
- 6 Scorekeepers (2)
- 7 Coordinator (1)
- 8 Coaches (2)
- 9 Audience

